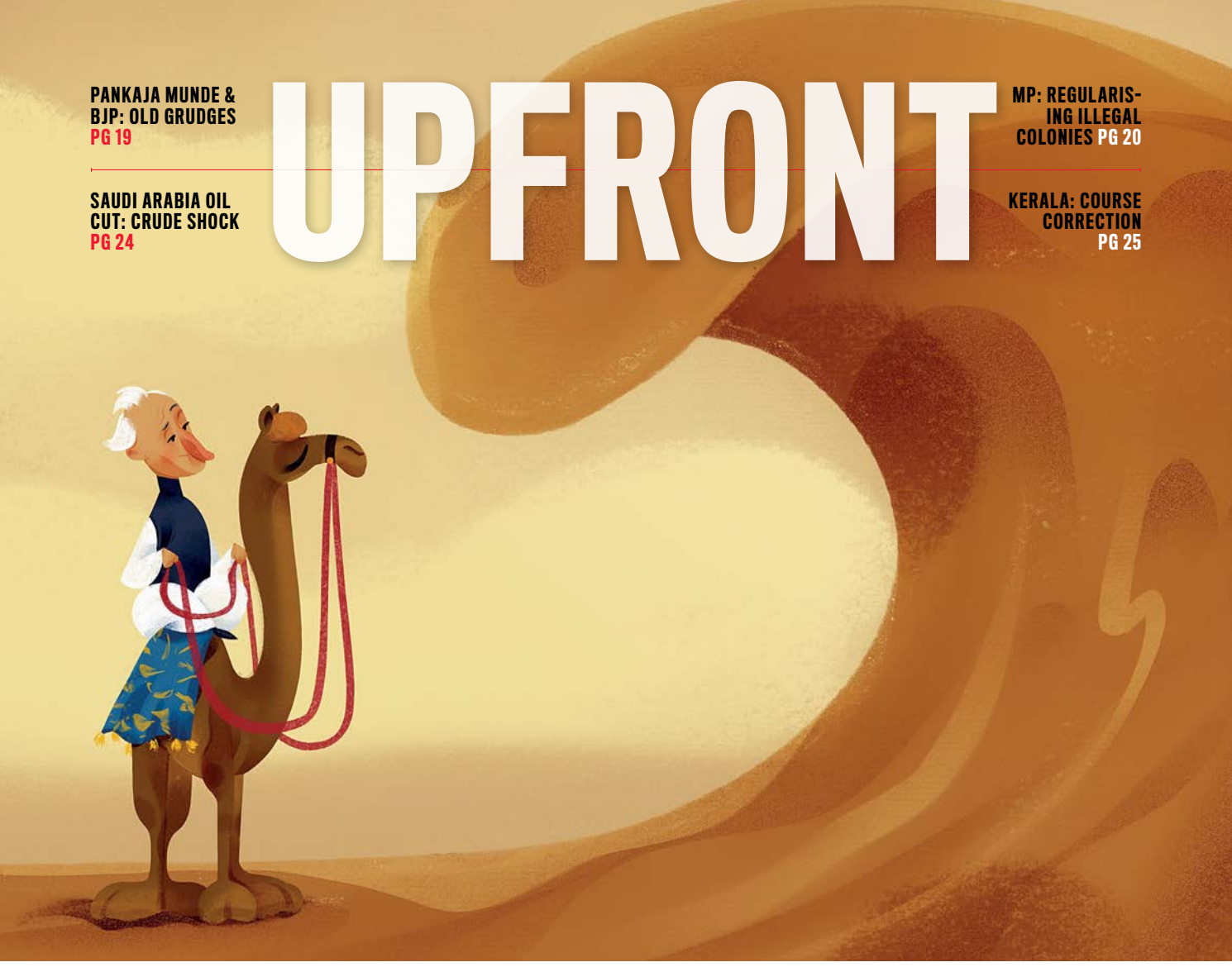
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RAJASTHAN POLLS

GEHLOT BRACES FOR OP. DESERT STORM

By Rohit Parihar

With elections coming up, can the Enforcement Directorate (ED) be far behind? Rajasthan has begun to get its share of ED attention ahead of the assembly election due in December. In a poll that could be more complex than the two-party battles of the past, the role of the central investigative agencies, in tandem with the infighting in both camps, is likely to add much bitterness to proceedings.

On June 9, the ED launched statewide raids on 27 locations to investigate the controversial question paper leaks in the Senior Teacher Grade II exam and REET (Rajasthan Eligibility Examination for Teachers)—a known vulnerable point for Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot. Mounting public pressure had already seen arrests in the case—including that of B.L. Katara, a sitting member of the Rajasthan Public Service Commission (RPSC), back in April. Now, signs are that the ED is widening the ambit of the probe beyond the Katara case.

Gehlot responded by going on the offensive, saying he was "expecting the central agencies" with elections round the corner, but asked, "Why hasn't the

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE